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Price: \$999 (Rs 43,000)

Playing God

For a long time, the idea of being able to create movie-style 3D graphics and imagery was quite preposterous. The average home PC couldn't take the load, and there weren't even that many commercially available tools for those who itched to bring their fantasies to life. The statement was clear—this was the domain of big studios who worked on expensive and powerful Silicon Graphics workstations.

Then came tools like 3D Studio Max, which ran on most respectable PC configurations and were so easy to use that one could become something of an expert just sitting at home! Specialised tools such as MetaCreations' (then Corel's and now DAZ

Studios') Bryce let you imitate nature and create ultra-realistic landscapes or bizarre fantasy worlds in minutes—even if you didn't know the first thing about 3D modelling.

The Big Gun: Autodesk Maya 7

The leader in creating special effects for movies (Spider-Man 2, for example), Maya is to 3D graphics what EA is to gaming. Designers cower in humility before it and even say a little prayer of thanks every time they work with it. Its powers are truly awe-inspiring, if not downright frightening. Capable of creating uncannily realistic images, Maya has all the features you could possibly need to get started with your own creation. To get a true sense of its power, take the "Fake or Foto" test: www.autodesk.com/eng/etc/fake_or_foto.

There was considerable paranoia when Autodesk, the makers of 3ds max, a close competitor to Maya, took over Alias|Wavefront—the developers of Maya; loyal users wondered if this rang the final bell for their favourite design tool. Thankfully, Autodesk seem committed to taking Maya further, so it will carry on as the industry's darling.

Price: Rs 3 lakh, but you can start learning Maya by downloading the Maya 7 Personal Learning

Edition free from www.autodesk.com. Maya isn't easy, though—you'll require plenty of patience.

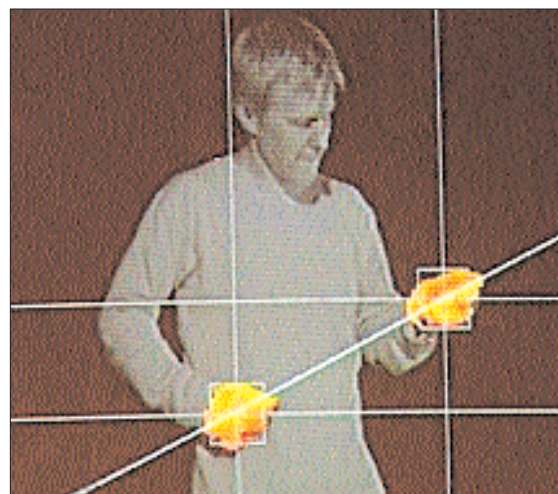
Home building comes home

Google has brought 3D graphics even closer to the home user with their new Google SketchUp, which makes designing houses and other buildings as easy as puffing your cheeks. Build your dream home or remodel your current one—thanks to its clean, intuitive interface and ridiculous ease of use, it'll be just minutes before you've mastered the art. More importantly, it's free, and you'll find it on this month's Digit CD!

Rock On

Peoples' fascination with creating their own music has led to many popular games such as *Guitar*

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Hero for the PS2, Nintendo's *Donkey Kong* and Namco's *Taiko Drum Master*. There are also plenty of tools that let you mix and create your own compositions—you can read about them in this month's *Fast Track*.

Fear My Virtual Axe

Want to be a rock god but can't handle a guitar to save your life? Students at the Helsinki Institute of Technology have developed Virtual Air Guitar, which translates those silly air guitar moves into actual sound! It uses a Web cam to watch your hand movements and throws out sound accordingly.

They're also working on a version that can work with our everyday Web cams, so now you don't need to jump on your bed looking like a nincompoop—you can sound like one too! ■

nimish_chandiramani@thinkdigit.com

